to me there's only one more I'm being allowed to play. Regardless, it would be difficult to find a cricket ground in the world so far opposed to Dharamshala, where I had last played a competitive game.

Southport, by contrast, is dwarfed by surrounding houses, not mountains, with a few rows of deck chairs and school chairs distancing the streets to the pitch. There is though a strange frostiness here too. A coldness inside and out. There has been rain and constant interruptions and I am the only one of 22 players who hasn't even walked out on the pitch yet. It's disorientating as the little out ground is unusually packed. People have travelled from miles around to see the game. Everyone keeps asking me how everything *feels* – how it feels that people have turned up just to see me, how it feels to be the last time, how it feels for it to be over. If I knew, I'd say. All I want to do is play cricket, to be in that safe space of semi-red mist with someone like Shubman Gill, where everything is simpler.

It's even weird with my other nemeses from around the world, who are now suddenly acting like they don't hate me anymore. Nathan Lyon is in the Lancashire team and he's being really friendly. I can't work out if I like it or not, but end up signing him a shirt, writing, 'I preferred you as a teammate to an opponent. Jimmy x'. People surround the path to the dressing room with messages and ask for photographs. All I'm thinking, all I will be thinking at Lord's too, is how do I not turn this into a procession? How do I not make this entirely about me but instead a game of competitive cricket, where that is all that matters? That's all I ever wanted. As I'm running back to the tiny dressing room having faced two balls, finally ready to bowl with Lancashire declaring to try to force a result, I decide to stop thinking; stop it all, block out all the cold and all the noise, and just let myself slip into the familiar safety of bowling.

I know how I *feel* with a ball in my hand. I feel really good. I feel really young. Every ball I bowl, I feel like I am going to take a wicket. The ball is doing stuff off the pitch I'd forgotten about; zipping through, rushing players for time, splaying off top edges and outside edges. Batters are squaring up, imagining the ball to be flickable through midwicket before it straightens late and leaves them stranded and twisted up. I'm floating through it, no coldness in my toes, no retirement in my mind, and look up at the scoreboard. I've taken six wickets for 18 runs in nine overs. There is